How brands get into AI answers, and what that means for Kays

What AI assistants actually do when a customer asks "which app should I use", where Kays stands today, why a dashboard is not the product, and the to-do list that moves the needle. Housedge, 26 October 2026.

In one paragraph. An AI assistant names a brand for one of two reasons: it already knew the brand from its training data, or it searched the web and the brand was on the pages it read. Kays fails both tests today. Asked for the best USD account app, Claude answered from memory and named Wise, Payoneer, Revolut, Mercury and Airwallex; it did not even search. Asked directly "is Kays legit?", it searched three times, found only joinkays.com, and told the user it *couldn't verify Kays is legitimate*. That is the whole job: get Kays into the sources AI reads, make it verifiable, and measure every week whether it worked. A person can ask ChatGPT once; they cannot see the sources behind the answer, cannot tell a 1-in-10 mention from a 9-in-10 mention, and cannot run the fixes. That gap is the product. The measurement alone is not: several tools sell dashboards. The to-do list and doing the work are what Kays pays €1,500 a month for.

0 of 2
generic "best USD app" answers that named Kays (Claude, 26 Oct)

0
reviews, press articles, Reddit threads or listicles about Kays found by web search

0
licence, partner or founder names on joinkays.com (AI looks for exactly these)

$0.17
cost of this 3-question probe (Sonnet, live web search)

1. What an AI assistant does with "which app should I use?"

1. Memory
If the model already knows the category well, it answers from training data and may not search at all. Only brands that were widely written about before the training cut-off exist here.

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2. Search
Otherwise it writes 1–5 search queries (sometimes already naming brands), reads the top results, and summarises them. Brands on those pages get named; others do not exist.

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3. Judgement
It weighs what it read: who is recommended by several sources, what the fees are, whether the company looks real (licence, reviews, press). Then it writes the answer, often with caveats.

What the evidence says about each step

FINDING	WHAT IT MEANS FOR A BRAND	SOURCE

Memory comes first. In our probe, Claude answered two generic questions without searching. Research on ChatGPT found brands named in its own search query appeared in the final answer 68.9% of the time, against 2.1% for brands it merely fetched.	If the model does not already associate your brand with the category, search rarely rescues you. Being "known" (many mentions across the web, over time) is the foundation.	Housedge probe; Search Engine Journal research as reported by Relevant Audience and DEV
Brand mentions beat backlinks. Ahrefs studied 75,000 brands: branded web mentions had the strongest correlation with appearing in Google AI Overviews (Spearman 0.664), ahead of branded anchors (0.527) and branded search volume (0.392).	Classic SEO link-building matters less than simply being talked about on many sites. PR, listicles, reviews and community threads are the lever.	Ahrefs, 75K brands
A few kinds of site get most citations. Across ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity and Google AI, the most-cited domains are Reddit, YouTube, Wikipedia, LinkedIn and editorial sites such as Forbes; for ChatGPT alone Wikipedia leads (about 13% of citations) with Reddit close behind. Only about 11% of domains are cited by both ChatGPT and Perplexity.	Each assistant reads a different web. Being on Wikipedia helps ChatGPT; YouTube and Reddit help Perplexity and Google; your own site is cited by all of them but is never enough on its own.	Peec AI, 30M sources; Search Engine Land; LLM Pulse
Search engines feed the assistants. Seer Interactive matched 87% of SearchGPT citations to Bing's top 20 results (2024 prototype). Later samples show the overlap shifting as OpenAI builds its own index, so treat the exact figure as dated.	Pages that rank for "best USD account for freelancers" are the pages the assistant reads. Getting onto those pages, or writing one that ranks, is still the main route in.	Seer Interactive; Ahrefs overlap study

What on a page gets it quoted. The Princeton/Georgia Tech GEO paper rewrote pages and measured how much of the answer they got. Adding quotations from sources: +41%. Adding statistics: +31%. Citing sources: +28%. Keyword stuffing: −8%. Gains were far larger for pages ranked 5th (+100 to +115%) than for pages ranked 1st (which lost share).	Pages with concrete numbers, quotable sentences and named sources win answer share, and the underdog gains most. "Send $200, $187 arrives elsewhere" is exactly the kind of sentence AI quotes, if it is on a page AI reads.	Aggarwal et al., KDD 2024
Place and language change the answer. Assistants pass the user's country to search; studies find local brands replacing global ones depending on language and location.	"Best USD account" asked from Pakistan and from Nigeria are different questions. Track per market.	arXiv study as reported in the sources above; our own Wolt test (Finland)
Verification is part of the judgement. When asked about an unknown brand, Claude searched for reviews, Trustpilot, BBB, app-store round-ups, news and Reddit, then listed what it would need to see: legal entity, regulator or MSB registration, who holds the money, where the yield comes from, named founders.	For a money app this is the make-or-break step. A brand with no third-party record is answered with a warning, not a recommendation.	Housedge probe, question 3 (verbatim below)

Caveat: most citation-share numbers come from vendors of AI-visibility tools, use different samples, and move quickly (Reddit's share of ChatGPT citations swung from roughly 60% to 10% within six weeks in 2025). Use them for direction, not decimals. The Ahrefs and GEO-paper figures are the most solid.

2. What AI says about Kays today

Three questions a Kays customer would ask, put to Claude Sonnet with live web search on 26 October 2026 (the same model "Run now" uses).

QUESTION	DID IT SEARCH?	BRANDS NAMED	KAYS
What is the best app to open a US dollar account as a freelancer living outside the United States?	No. Answered from memory: "based on my general knowledge. I haven't searched for current details."	Wise (#1), Payoneer, Mercury, Brex, Relay, Airwallex, Revolut	**Not named**

I am a digital nomad: which app should I use to receive USD payments from clients and spend them with a card worldwide?	No. Answered from memory.	Wise (#1), Payoneer, Revolut, Mercury, Relay, Charles Schwab, "stablecoin options with a crypto card"	**Not named**
Is Kays (joinkays.com) a legitimate money app? What do people say about it?	Yes, three searches: "Kays joinkays.com money app review legit", "Kays app stablecoin dollar account joinkays", "Kays money app Trustpilot reviews".	Only joinkays.com found; the other results were Kay Jewelers, Kays furniture (Switzerland) and Kaysband.	**"I couldn't verify that Kays is legitimate"**

> *"I found no Trustpilot page, BBB listing, app-store review roundup, news coverage or Reddit discussion about it. […] I couldn't find who runs it, whether it is registered or licensed, or who holds the money. A lack of reviews doesn't mean it's a scam. It more likely means the app is new or small." Then: "Apps that offer 'yield' on dollar balances carry more risk than ordinary bank accounts."*

In the second question Claude did mention Kays' category ("stablecoin options with a crypto card") as a generic option with "more risk and tax complexity". That is the slot Kays competes for, and today it is filled by a warning, not a name.

The website, as a crawler sees it

CHECK	JOINKAYS.COM TODAY	WHY IT MATTERS TO AI
Page title and description	**Title is just "Kays". No meta description.**	The first two things every search index and assistant reads. "Kays" alone collides with a jeweller, a catalogue and a furniture shop.
Company facts in structured data	**None (no JSON-LD).**	Organization data with sameAs links to the App Store, Google Play, X and Instagram is how machines learn that these are all the same Kays.
About, pricing, FAQ pages	**None. One page plus Terms and Privacy. The Terms refer to a "Kays Fee Schedule published on the Platform" that is not on the site.**	Assistants quote fee pages and FAQs. "One flat fee" with no number cannot be compared with Wise's 0.5–0.7%.
Licence, partners, custody, founders	**"Licensed partners", unnamed. Entity: KAYS-FI INC, Delaware. No regulator, no bank, no founder names. LinkedIn link is a placeholder.**	Exactly the list Claude said it needs before it will call a money app legitimate.
Readable without JavaScript, language, https	**Webflow page, server-rendered text, lang="en", https.**	Fine.
App store presence	**Live on the App Store (Pakistan storefront) and Google Play.**	Store listings are sources assistants read; reviews there count. Today they are not found.

3. "Can't a person just ask ChatGPT?" Yes. Here is what they cannot do.

ONE PERSON, ONE CHAT	HOUSEDGE
Gets one answer. Ask again tomorrow, from another country, or on Gemini, and it changes. In our Wolt test the same model named Foodora's closure in 5 answers out of 10.	Asks every question on every assistant, in every market, every week, and reports a **share** with a confidence range: "named in 60–75% of answers", not "ChatGPT said X once".
Sees the answer, not the cause.	Keeps every answer with the **sources it cited**. That is where the to-do list comes from: which listicles, review sites and threads shaped the answer, and which of them you are missing from.
Reads the answer and guesses what it means.	Reads every answer with the same method: recommended, listed, compared or warned against; rank; tone; with the sentence that proves it. Same method for Wolt, Kays and a casino.
Has no baseline, so cannot show progress.	Freezes the numbers in a report each month. "Named in 0% of answers in October, 40% in January" is the renewal conversation.
Knows something is wrong, not what to do first.	Turns the gap into ordered actions with the evidence attached (section 4), and **Housedge does the work**: the pages, the outreach, the listings, the fixes.

Be honest about what is and is not the product. The dashboard is the instrument. Several companies sell AI-visibility dashboards already (Profound, Peec AI, Otterly, Scrunch and others), and a technical client could build the probe above in an afternoon. What a client cannot buy off the shelf is: a method that reads any industry with evidence, the diagnosis of *why*, a prioritised plan, and a team that executes it and proves the result. Sell the outcome ("AI names you when your customers ask") and the proof; the dashboard is how we show our work.

Two things this probe teaches us about our own product

- **Assistants often answer from memory.** Through the API, Claude chose not to search for generic questions even though search was available. The Claude app searches more readily. We should record for every answer whether the assistant searched (we already store the search count: 0 means memory) and show it, because "known from memory" and "found by search" need different fixes. We may also want a setting per project: let the assistant decide (closest to a real customer) or require a search (closest to current facts).
- **Verification questions are a category of their own.** "Is X legit?" is answered by searching for reviews, regulators and press. Every onboarding should include it, and the to-do list should treat "verifiable" as the first milestone for young brands.

4. The Kays to-do list, in order

Ordered by how much each step moves AI answers for the cost. Baseline today: named in 0% of answers; "cannot verify" when asked directly.

#	ACTION	WHY (EVIDENCE)	OWNER, EFFORT	WHAT SHOULD CHANGE
1	**Make Kays verifiable.** Publish on joinkays.com: the legal entity and Delaware address (already in the Terms, not on the site), the *named* partner that issues cards and holds accounts, where the ~3% yield comes from and who holds the T-bills, whether balances are insured or segregated, founders with LinkedIn profiles, a working LinkedIn company page, and the Fee Schedule the Terms promise. Add an "Is Kays safe?" FAQ answering each of these in one plain sentence.	These are, word for word, the things Claude listed as missing before it would call Kays legitimate. Until they exist, every "is Kays legit?" answer is a warning. Also fixes the pricing gap: "one flat fee" cannot be compared with Wise's published 0.5–0.7%.	Kays (facts), Housedge (pages, schema). 1–2 weeks.	"Is Kays legit?" answers stop saying "couldn't verify" within 2–4 weeks of indexing.
2	**Get onto the pages AI reads for the category.** The listicles that rank for "USD account for freelancers / digital nomads": nsave, Afriex, HoyaPay, Utoppia, GrabrFi, Higlobe, Jobbers, WorldFirst's freelancer guides, plus the Pakistan- and Nigeria-specific ones. Pitch inclusion, offer a comparison with numbers, or publish Kays' own "best USD accounts for freelancers in Pakistan (2026)" comparison page built to rank and to be quoted (statistics, named sources, quotable sentences).	Assistants summarise the top search results; brand mentions correlate with AI visibility (0.66) far more than backlinks. The GEO paper shows pages with statistics and citations gain the most answer share, and lower-ranked pages gain most (+100%).	Housedge (outreach and writing), Kays (facts, screenshots). 4–8 weeks, ongoing.	Kays appears in search-grounded answers for category questions, first in PK and NG.

3	**Third-party record: reviews and community.** Claim and build the Trustpilot page; ask real users for App Store and Google Play reviews; launch on Product Hunt (KOSH, a direct competitor, is there); take part honestly in r/freelance, r/digitalnomad, r/pakistan, r/Nigeria threads about getting paid in USD, and in Facebook freelancer groups; answer "how do I get a USD account" questions as Kays, with disclosure.	Reddit, YouTube and review sites are the most-cited domains across assistants; "what do people say about it" is answered from exactly these. Claude searched for "Kays money app Trustpilot reviews" and found nothing.	Kays (users, founders' time), Housedge (plan, drafts, monitoring). Ongoing from week 1.	"What do people say" answers cite reviews and threads; sentiment measurable.
4	**Fix the site for machines.** Page title "Kays: USD account, card and transfers for freelancers and nomads"; meta description; Organization JSON-LD with legalName, address, logo and sameAs (App Store, Google Play, X, Instagram, Facebook, LinkedIn); FAQPage schema on the FAQ; separate About and Pricing pages; llms.txt; confirm robots.txt allows OAI-SearchBot, Claude-SearchBot, PerplexityBot, Googlebot. (Housedge's website check and the ready-to-paste code in Optimise do most of this.)	Entity clarity: "Kays" alone resolves to a jeweller. sameAs links tell every index that joinkays.com, the app listings and the social accounts are one company. Structured data and FAQs are what assistants quote.	Housedge, Kays' web developer. 1 week.	Website check score from today's level to 90+; fewer Kay-Jewelers mix-ups.
5	**Name consistency and the knowledge graph.** Use "Kays money app" / "Kays (joinkays.com)" everywhere the brand is written online, including store listings and social bios. Create a Wikidata item (legal name, website, app IDs, founding year, HQ). Wikipedia only when there is independent press to cite.	Wikipedia and Wikidata are top ChatGPT sources and the backbone of entity recognition; without them "Kays" stays ambiguous.	Housedge. Days (Wikidata), months (Wikipedia).	Direct questions resolve to the right Kays every time.
6	**Quotable facts and stats on the site.** A comparison page with real numbers: "Sending $200 by a typical remittance app: $187 arrives. Sending $200 with Kays: $X arrives", fee tables against Wise, Payoneer, Grey and KOSH, dated, with sources.	Statistics (+31%) and quotations (+41%) are the strongest page-level levers in the GEO paper. The "$187" line is already on the site but not in a form anyone can cite.	Housedge (page), Kays (the real fee figures).	Kays' own page becomes a cited source in fee questions.

7	**Press.** One founder story and one data story (for example "what freelancers in Pakistan actually pay to receive $1,000") placed in fintech and freelancer media, in Pakistan and Nigeria first.	Editorial domains (Forbes-type) are top ChatGPT sources; press is also the "named founders with verifiable backgrounds" signal.	Housedge, 1–3 months.	Mentions in editorial sources; memory-level recall over time.
8	**Measure weekly in Housedge.** The default questionnaire plus the five Kays questions, on ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity and Claude, markets PK and NG; monthly report.	Answers vary; only repeated sampling shows a trend. The baseline is set now, so the before/after is provable.	Housedge, automatic.	Share of answers naming Kays, with confidence ranges, per assistant and market.

Expected trajectory (judgement, not a promise): weeks 2–4, verification answers improve as the new pages are indexed; months 1–3, Kays appears in search-grounded category answers in PK and NG; months 3–9, memory-level recall starts to show in assistants' un-searched answers as mentions accumulate and models are retrained. Measure against that, and say so to the client.

5. What is set up in the app

- **Onboarding pre-filled with Kays** (local demo): company, brand and aliases, five competitors (Wise, Payoneer, Grey, KOSH, Revolut), markets Pakistan and Nigeria, starter questions for "USD accounts for freelancers" plus five Kays-specific questions including "Is Kays (joinkays.com) a legit money app?", the full business profile from the site, goals and the "what AI gets wrong" answer from this report.
- **Not run yet:** the full check (about 20 questions × Claude, roughly $1.30 with Sonnet). It is one click as the Kays client after onboarding; this report's probe cost $0.17 for three questions.

Sources used: the Housedge probe (Claude Sonnet 5.5, web search, 26 Oct 2026); joinkays.com, its Terms of Service (updated September 2026) and app listings; Aggarwal et al., "GEO: Generative Engine Optimization", KDD 2024 (arXiv 2311.09735); Ahrefs, "An Analysis of AI Overview Brand Visibility Factors (75K brands)"; Peec AI, "Top domains cited by AI search (30M sources)"; Search Engine Land, "AI search engines cite Reddit, YouTube and LinkedIn most"; LLM Pulse top-cited domains; Seer Interactive, "87% of SearchGPT citations match Bing's top results"; Ahrefs, "AI search overlap"; Relevant Audience and DEV Community summaries of Search Engine Journal's brand pre-selection research. Vendor figures are directional.